

KEJRIWAL IS TARGET Delhi deputy CM Manish Sisodia at a presser, Aug. 20

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DELHI

SOMETHING BREWING

By Kaushik Deka

The Aam Aadmi Party and its supremo, Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, have often been floated as 'The Alternative'—filling the perceived vacuum in the Opposition space left by a shrinking Congress. The victory in Punjab this spring reinforced that impression, and with upcoming elections in Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh offering AAP another chance to burnish its national credentials, the BJP does not seem inclined to take the threat lightly. Sidelong confirmation of that came on August 19, when the CBI conducted raids in over 20 locations in Delhi and elsewhere, including at the residence of deputy CM Manish Sisodia. An FIR, registered two days earlier, had made the stunning claim that Sisodia, as architect of the state's excise policy for 2021-22, which was rolled out last November, took dodgy and unapproved decisions to extend undue favours to liquor traders. The agency has named 14 others as accused in the alleged scam.

The probe was recommended by Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on July 21, a fortnight after Delhi chief secretary Naresh Kumar submit-